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Objects and Affects

Objects and relations

Is an object something that exists in and of itself? Or does it exist only in relation to something else—a subject that sees it, that uses it? The past decade has seen the rise of a number of competing perspectives that theorize the role of objects in shaping and determining culture, possessive of agencies that exist beyond human experience and knowledge. Some argue that objects are completely withdrawn, separate and independent from human thought. Others argue that objects exist only in relation. In this chapter, we'll attempt to negotiate between these two perspectives, using them to craft a theory of objects and relations that adds to our emphasis on the politics of materiality. *the epistemological turn*

Can we come up with a way of describing what objects do that isn't all about me, or you, or any other human being using them? By the end of the following pages we'll be able to answer this question in the affirmative—we do have ways of thinking about objects that do not defer to human thought and intent. But, this chapter is a bit of a departure from our previous ones. Much of what we'll cover in it has a hostile relationship to materiality, tending to make objects into metaphysical things that exceed material reality and—consequently—the ability of an observer to grasp and understand them. Embracing a metaphysics of objects is not something a materialist theory of media should do, so, in looking at what objects are, we'll think through the strengths and weaknesses of some of these theories and work to fold these theories into the version of materialism we've been sketching throughout this book—a task that is not without its limitations.

Subjects and objects

Philosophers have often started their speculations by looking at their desk and the objects they find there. Edmund Husserl, the philosopher most associated with **phenomenology** as a method and body of thought, once wrote,

I am aware of a world, spread out in space endlessly, and in time becoming and become, without end. I am aware of it, that means, first of all, I discover it immediately, intuitively. I experience it. Through sight, touch, hearing, etc., in the different ways of sensory perception, corporeal things somehow spatially distributed are *for me simply there* . . . whether or not I pay them special attention by busying myself with them, considering, thinking, feeling, willing. (1931, 51)

This seeming infinitude of the world is discovered immediately, intuitively, at Husserl's desk where he writes, with what is *present* in front of him. Sitting at his desk, Husserl can let his "attention wander from the writing-table I have just seen and observed," meaning he can think about objects even if they're not immediately in front of his face, present to his immediate sensation, like his desk. But, when right there in front of him, "Things in their immediacy stand there as objects to be used, the 'table' with its 'books,' the 'glass to drink from,' the 'vase,' the 'piano,' and so forth" (52–53). Husserl's point is that, while he begins with the objects and things around him, he doesn't apprehend—or experience in consciousness—all of what is physically present in the same way. He knows that a world exists beyond his immediate experience even if he doesn't see it directly. He knows that specific objects exist in front of him, but he can ignore them as he contemplates the infinitude of the world. For phenomenology, which is a philosophical method designed to reveal the essences of the world through a process of "reduction," a process Husserl named the *epoché*, or "bracketing," which entails removing that which is inessential from thought, Husserl necessarily begins with what's there on his desk. Even the most abstract speculation begins somewhere concrete, with the objects and things that are there, within grasping distance. But the point of doing this is to give a transcendental understanding of reality, beyond the immanence of the material things that are present. Husserl begins with the objects in front of him to get beyond them, finding the "essences" of reality.

So, when phenomenologists look at and take hold of the objects around them, what conclusions do they make? The things in front of Husserl, as he notes, are there to be *used*. We may experience something we use differently than something we see, or something we recall in our memory. The philosopher Martin Heidegger, who was a student of Husserl's, makes a similar point when he distinguishes between what he terms "*present-at-hand*" and "*ready-to-hand*." A technology's "readiness-to-hand" is linked with its use—each technology is designed to be used in particular ways. "The shoe which is to be produced is for wearing . . . the clock is manufactured for telling the time. The work . . . has a usability which belongs to it essentially; in this usability it lets us encounter already the 'towards-which' for which it is

immediacy

usable" (1962, 99). There's a proper use of particular objects, a use that seems to be "in" the object itself but isn't always self-evident. A hammer, for instance, is only properly used when one holds the bottom of its handle, tightly in the grip of one's hand. Holding a hammer in this way permits the weight of its head to strike a nail with the most force—but the specific location of holding a hammer isn't always obvious unless one has been taught how to properly use a hammer. Perhaps one grasps the hammer's handle too high, or even grasps the head. The same can be said of many technologies, including a range of digital media. Why would we assume the gestures that control an iPhone, like pinching with two fingers to zoom in, or swiping left or right, to be self-evident? We have to learn the proper use of our technologies, often through some kind of education—much of which is built into a technology itself. But, for Heidegger, in being used, in being "ready-to-hand," a technology ~~(invisible)~~ *withdraws* from our experience of it. If we're adept at using a hammer, we won't see it, or even feel it as something independent of our body. It will function as an **extension of the body**—an argument that links Heidegger with McLuhan. When we swipe left or right on our phone, we shouldn't notice the mechanics built into a device's interface—a common sentiment in interface design (see Emerson 2014). Rather, our bodies have been trained to act in a particular way that causes us to ignore or forget the technologies we use and the techniques we perform, internalizing them as habit.

Heidegger tells us that the "essence" of a particular technology is only disclosed in its use. But, in being used, a technology ceases to be something we experience and contemplate. Something is "present-at-hand"—rather than ready-to-hand—only when we encounter it outside of its use. This happens when something breaks, and we see it outside of our use of it—we experience it as an object. We don't notice the hammer unless we're using it incorrectly or if the head snaps off from the handle. We don't notice our phones except when they're not working correctly. A phone would be most present when it drops a call or when its batteries fully deplete. We can only experience something as an object when it's not doing what it's supposed to be doing or when it disrupts its relation it has as an extension of the body. The irony here is that it is only in its withdrawal from our experience, in its being used, that we can encounter what Heidegger says is the essence of a technology. But it is only when a technology is present-at-hand that we can begin to contemplate it and its ontology. *"Readiness-to-hand is the way in which entities as they are 'in themselves' are defined ontologico-categorically.* Yet only by reason of something present-at-hand, 'is there' anything ready-to-hand" (Heidegger 1962, 101).

*visibility
upon
breakdown*

Both Husserl and Heidegger want to get to the ontology of our world, of humanity, of experience. But, Heidegger tells us, technology fundamentally

obscures this by shaping what we experience and see—it's almost impossible to get to the essence of the things around us, because, in their use, their essence withdraws. And, as Husserl's example unintentionally reveals to us, we don't pay attention to everything equally. Some things are more important than others; some things we pay attention to and others bleed into the background, forgotten. The objects around me are only selectively present. When you focus on something in your vision, what's around it becomes hazy. Your attention to one thing makes the others around it into a background upon which the object of your attention emerges as distinct (cf. Bollmer and Guinness 2017). This is not even to mention that, in the process of his phenomenological analysis, Husserl does away with the physical things around him to get to what he thinks is the ontological reality buried beneath appearances. For Husserl, understanding reality requires us to reduce the material specificity away to approach the essences of experience. What matters, Husserl implies, is not the specific things in front of him, but the fact that he has a particular relationship with some of them—a relationship he terms “intentionality”—that allows him to be directed at some objects but not others.

Cultural theorist Sara Ahmed finds these reflections of Husserl's fascinating, but not entirely because of Husserl's conclusions:

How I long for him to dwell there by lingering on the folds of the materials that surround him. How I long to hear about the objects that gather around him, as “things” he does “things” with. This is not a desire for biography, or even for an impossible intimacy with a writer who is no longer with us. This is, rather, a desire to read about the particularity of the objects that gather around the writer. (2006, 29)

Ahmed's brilliant interpretation of Husserl remakes his focus on intentionality to one of *orientation*. We not only intend a particular object in consciousness but also are *oriented* toward particular objects, which causes some objects to emerge in our perception more easily than others. We attend to them, but, in so doing, neglect others—we place others in the background, forgetting them, hiding them, acting as if their agencies do not matter. Our bodies are predisposed toward seeing some things and not others. But, even beyond the physiological capacities a body has for sensation, we often overlook and ignore particular objects, bodies, and relations. Ahmed, in revising Husserl, makes his arguments political. As she continues,

Being oriented toward the writing table not only relegates other rooms in the house to the background, but also might depend *on the work done*

to keep the desk clear. . . . One might even consider the domestic work that must have taken place for Husserl to turn to the writing table, and to be writing on the table, and to keep that table as the object of his attention. . . . Who faces the writing table? Does the writing table have a face, which points it toward some bodies rather than others? (30–32)

Even acts like observing objects on a table and sitting down to read or write involve numerous material facts—not all of which are equally distributed, not all of which are equally acknowledged as “material.”

Ahmed draws us to how materiality is, once again, a *process of mattering*, one in which a range of subjects and objects are linked in relation, but in which these relations are inequivalent, even oppositional. The lived experience of race and racism, for instance, allows some objects to become present, while others may never materialize. The phrase “I don’t see race,” so often uttered by white people denying accusations of racism, is a refusal to allow race to materialize. It is not an ontological claim, but one that denies specific objects and relations to emerge in perception. The denial of seeing race is a disqualification of race as a category, one that refuses the lived experience of race to materialize, perpetuating the inequalities of racism. “Race” becomes something excluded from one’s world, refusing to let it be acknowledged, refusing to let it exist as sensible. This, consequentially, perpetuates racism by refusing the realities of racial difference and discrimination.

I begin with Husserl and Heidegger, along with Ahmed’s interpretation of Husserl, for a number of reasons, reasons that will be woven throughout the remainder of this chapter. First is that Husserl is often thought to most clearly represent a number of tendencies in Western philosophy today disparaged from a number of directions. Namely, his theories all begin with a perceiving ego or subject. Even if Husserl sees a material object, what matters to him are the ideas in his mind, not the physical thing. Objects do not seem to matter in and of themselves. They only matter as something that exist within his consciousness of them. This tendency has been recently termed “*correlationism*.” The critique of correlationism (and of philosophers like Husserl) suggests that philosophy and theory today should acknowledge a world that exists beyond the human, and objects should be able to exist outside of a human perceiver’s experience of them. So, we should work to understand the objects on my desk divorced from how I apprehend them, rather than a Husserlian view that begins with my experience of the world around me. This is, at least in part, where Heidegger’s comments on ready-to-hand and present-at-hand lead us. Heidegger’s argument suggests that objects, in their material presence, “dematerialize” to our experience of them, reduced to extensions of the human body. It is only when they break that

they become “present.” But to grasp the object’s ontology is to begin with it in use—to begin when we do not see it or experience it. A number of followers of Heidegger, particularly a group of philosophers who have embraced the name “Object-Oriented Ontology” (or “OOO”) have latched upon this idea. Objects, in their real, material existence, are fundamentally *withdrawn* and separate from human experience (and from each other). Objects, following Heidegger, are isolated and independent, and approaching them in relation inherently reduces the object by placing it in relation. These authors—some of whom reject much of the materialist theory we’ve covered in this book—are seemingly content in identifying the Otherness and autonomy of objects, the fact that objects resist any coherent theorization because of their withdrawal.

My view is that we can admit that objects are withdrawn without rejecting their relationality and their materiality. Ahmed’s reading of Husserl transforms phenomenology into a kind of materialism, one that stresses how relations permit specific objects to materialize while others fail to materialize as they become rendered background. Ahmed doesn’t deny the Otherness of objects or the Otherness of others. But she directs us to how the relations between bodies and between objects are locations for political struggle. It is in the negotiation of relation that we can see how some objects “materialize” while others do not. Once again, we see flashes of the politics behind how we’ve been theorizing performative materialism with our emphasis on relation and intra-action.

To emphasize once again the importance of relation, this chapter will take up themes from *vital materialism*. Vital materialism is a name associated with the work of political theorist Jane Bennett and primarily refers to “the capacity of things—edibles, commodities, storms, metals—not only to impede or block the will and designs of humans but also to act as quasi agents or forces with trajectories, propensities, or tendencies of their own” (2010, viii). Vitalism is linked with the physical capacity to affect and be affected, and thus requires us to bring in questions of affect theory, which allows us to synthesize some of the claims of Chapter 4 with those reviewed here.

These two perspectives—the “withdrawn” objects of OOO, and the affects and energies of vital materialism—have problems on their own, especially regarding knowledge and agency. Both imply significant difficulties in knowing or doing much of anything and are limited by a pessimistic philosophy that suggests it’s neither possible nor desirable to work to change the world—a pessimism that often comes disguised as a form of progressive politics. These problems are another reason I’ve foregrounded Sara Ahmed, as I think Ahmed, along with Katherine Behar, who has revised OOO into *Object-Oriented Feminism* (or “OOF”), gives us tools through which to synthesize the best aspects of these two directions to theorize the agency of

this seems to suggest a degree of sympathy between vital materialism and new materialism

objects. We should maintain OOO's emphasis on the alterity of objects and should embrace the relationality of vital materialism, placing them together to acknowledge an intra-active politics that still permits human intervention and agency in affecting material relations.

Objects and things

We now need to specify some of our terms, which also allows us to show why these theories of objects are often at odds with materialist perspectives. In the history of philosophy, there's a major distinction between a "thing" and an "object." Heidegger, in an essay titled "The Thing," thinks about a jug in detail, extending and revising his comments about the presence of objects and their essences:

But what is a thing? . . . The jug is a thing. What is the jug? We say: a vessel, something of the kind that holds something else within it. The jug's holding is done by its base and sides. This container itself can again be held by the handle. As a vessel the jug is something self-sustained, something that stands on its own. This standing on its own characterizes the jug as something that is self-supporting, or independent. As the self-supporting independence of something independent, the jug differs from an object. (1971, 164)

While Heidegger begins by talking about the jug in its materiality, he's pointing to how these material facts about the jug cannot fully define what the jug is. If we think back to Heidegger's emphasis on the ready-at-hand, what he's highlighting here is how the *use* of the jug cannot be located within its materiality, properly speaking. The jug independently "supports" something independent. The materiality gives form to something else; the water in the jug, according to Heidegger, is not "in" it, it is independent, it does not physically merge with the materiality of the container. The function of a jug—which, for Heidegger, is the creation of an empty void that can be filled with other substances—is not about the substance of the jug itself, organized into its base and sides. It's not about the fact that we can hold the handle of the jug, holding the void created by the base and sides. It's not about the form of that which is contained within the jug. And it's not about the potter making the jug, as one cannot, properly speaking, "make" a void. Heidegger, interestingly, describes a jug as something autonomous from human agency, active in and of itself, and *in excess* of its material grounding (cf. Sofia 2000). What makes a jug a thing

rather than an object is this excess beyond the material. The word “thing” refers to “a certain limit or liminality,” literary theorist Bill Brown tells us, it exists at “the threshold between the nameable and unnamable, the figurable and unfigurable, the identifiable and unidentifiable: Dr. Seuss’s Thing One and Thing Two” (2001, 5). For Heidegger, Brown summarizes, a thing “is obscured by mere objects” (2003, 141).

In psychoanalysis, a thing becomes “the Thing,” or *das Ding*, and represents the object “lost” in the course of psychological development, the unknown Thing that will eventually lead to satisfaction and happiness, the “thing” that orients desire. “The world of our experience,” Jacques Lacan claims, “assumes that it is this object, *das Ding*, as the absolute Other of the subject, that one is supposed to find again. It is to be found at the most as something missed” (1992, 52). If only we’d find “the Thing,” psychoanalysis suggests, we’d feel whole and happy, we’d fill the empty void in our soul—though finding this Thing is ultimately impossible. The Thing, instead, is an impossibility that marks the existence of an absence—a void.

An object, formalized in Lacanian psychoanalysis as the *objet petit a*, is the object-cause of desire, the obtaining of which one imagines as leading toward satisfaction. (This is expressed as something like, “If I could only have *x*, then I’d be happy,” with *x* being, say, anything one desires, from a particular item of food, a commodity, even another person, or a part of another person.) But, like *das Ding*, this object is never to be obtained—or, “satisfaction” is never attained even when one is able to possess the object that guides their desire. The true “object”—the Thing that will result in satisfaction—is forever missed. Psychoanalysis argues that we don’t actually want to be happy—we want to keep on desiring more. Material objects are effaced for their role in directing desire, in which the material object obscures something else that can never be obtained. So—even though these terms are ultimately conflated in Lacanian psychoanalysis—there’s a split between “things” and “objects,” between an immaterial excess and material reality.

When philosophers tend to describe “things” they mean something that *exceeds materiality*. This excess still exists when people talk of objects in general, and it allows “objectification” to be a tool of critique. An argument throughout the history of feminist thought—both philosophical and popular—is that representations perpetuate patriarchal norms and misogyny by objectifying women’s bodies. Rather than a full subject, women are devalued into objects. This happens through, for instance, the common tendency in advertising that cuts up women’s bodies, or replaces body parts with commodities, or highlights some equivalence between a body part and a commodity. A notorious series of advertisements for the designer Tom Ford’s fragrances, for instance, equates bottles of perfume and cologne with

both male and female genitalia. Though these particular ads are egregious examples of objectification, this technique happens throughout advertising. The point is that objectification happens when bodies and people are treated as if they're interchangeable with objects that are bought and sold, when, in actuality, one's essence as a subject exceeds the body's reduction to an object.

The feminist philosopher Nina Power has noted how contemporary life appears to be colonized by a number of seemingly different forces that make critiques of objectification difficult. On the one hand, contemporary capital is no longer about workers manufacturing products, but—through neoliberal, informational capital and the rise of service work—about manufacturing identities and relationships. This transformation is often referred to as “immaterial labor” (see Lazzarato 1996), but in the 1980s and 1990s it was also referred to as the “feminization of labor,” as service jobs were traditionally held by women, and interpersonal labor has—and continues to be—labor performed mostly by women. If capital produces objects—as in, the worker's labor produces commodities to be bought and sold, which obscure the material forces and relations involved in the production of a commodity (this obscuring is what Marxist theory means by “commodity fetishism”)—then today the main object one produces is one's body and identity. This is combined with recent changes in visual culture and sexuality—in which, Power argues, “parts” of bodies “take on the function of the whole,” and parts of bodies are treated “as *wholly separate entities*, with little to no connection to themselves, their personality, or even the rest of their body” (2009, 24).

Combined, contemporary capital and visual culture result in an erosion of the divide between subject and object, one linked with the kinds of excess identified in theories of things. Where past forms of feminist thought critiqued larger practices of objectification, be it how the male gaze and heterosexuality fragmented women's bodies into their parts (following a Lacanian understanding of sexual desire, fixated on particular “objects” as it is), or critiquing how patriarchy tends to reduce women to objects, rather than subjects, this no longer seems to be the case:

Objectification implies that there is something left over in the subject that resists such a capture, that we might protest if we thought someone was trying to deny such interiority, but it's not clear that contemporary work allows anyone to have an inner life in the way we might once have understood it. . . . If feminism is to have a future, it has to recognize the new ways in which life and existence are colonized by new forms of domination that go far beyond objectification as it used to be understood. (Power 2009, 26)

The cry of “objectification” was potent because it identified specific moments in which bodies, agencies, and subjects would be reduced to objects to be used, objects lacking their own interiority and autonomy. But, Power notes, this reduction seems to be a generalized condition today, and—if the distinction between things and objects teaches us anything—this interiority or excess has long been an attribute of particular objects, ones thought to be special “things” because of how their essences exceeded their materiality. An illustration of the limits of objectification as a critique, following Power, would be the bottle of KKW Body, a perfume produced by Kim Kardashian. The KKW Body’s bottle is based off of a mold of Kardashian’s torso, without head, arms, or legs. Kardashian—whose fame is linked heavily with the use of social media, reality television, and self-branding—has embraced the reduction of herself to an object to perpetuate fame and stardom over social media. Critiquing this as objectification isn’t really helpful, because the current context suggests that there’s an exceptional amount of value that comes from self-objectification.

So, there’s a tradition in continental philosophy that uses the term “thing” to note how the essence of an object exceeds its material existence. This is a problem when it comes to uses of “objectification” as a means for critique, and it’s a problem for materialist theory—or, at least, this highlights how materialist theory understands objects and things differently than many philosophies of “things” elsewhere. The emphasis on excess, however, characterizes a great deal of current work on objects, even if the term “thing” isn’t applied in a way that follows Heidegger or Lacan. It’s to these recent attempts to theorize objects that we now turn.

Withdrawn objects

Over the past decade, a set of new philosophical movements have emerged, provoked by a number of problems including not only climate change and the immanent potential of human extinction but also the fact that our technologies and media clearly have agency in shaping the world in which we live, agencies that exist independent of human will and intention. These movements are Speculative Realism (or SR) and OOO. While they’re not the same and shouldn’t be completely conflated, OOO is an outgrowth of some of the issues and concerns of SR. SR and OOO have been widely debated in the past few years and have been influential for art, architecture, and a number of other theoretical debates. They originated out of a critique of Western philosophy that, at first blush, appeared to be quite political, as it

rejected the **anthropocentrism** that's long characterized Western thought and seemed to signal a new way of approaching ecological issues and indigenous politics, overturning a number of tropes that privilege limited versions of Enlightenment rationality, encoded as "modernity" in Western thought (cf. Latour 1993). As SR and OOO have developed over the past few years, however, they've lost their political thrust. What I want to do here is highlight a few key claims of SR and OOO, along with the limitations of these perspectives. I'm more interested in these bodies of theory because of the problems they've set up rather than the answers they supply: this includes addressing the agency of media and technology, the agencies of things and objects. But the way they answer these problems is, in my opinion, unsatisfying.

SR's emergence signaled a rejection of theories and philosophies that focused on language and social construction. The publication of the collection *The Speculative Turn* (Bryant, Srnicek, and Harman, 2011) was a manifesto that identified a group of younger theorists who were tired of the focus on language, discourse, and representation, instead looking elsewhere, be it to "reality" or to materiality. One of its editors, Nick Srnicek, stated the following in an interview:

Do we really need another analysis of how a cultural representation does symbolic violence to a marginal group? This is not to say that this work has been useless, just that it's become repetitive. In light of all that, speculative realism provides the best means for creative work to be done, and it provides genuine excitement to think that there are new argumentative realms to explore. (Quoted in Bogost 2012, 132)

Given the visible rise in authoritarian racism, misogyny, and xenophobia exposed in recent years—racism, misogyny, and xenophobia that never vanished but was ignored by those like Srnicek—this comment is deeply misguided (and I think has been repudiated by a lot of Srnicek's own work since he spoke these words, which has addressed issues of race, gender, and sexuality—at least to some extent—with a model derived more from Marx than SR). But it nonetheless speaks of a general orientation of many of the writers associated with these philosophical movements. Questions of representation and symbolic violence were not "real" in a number of ways. Instead, the focus should be on "reality," in such a way to move beyond the limits of human experience and knowledge.

While many of the authors affiliated with SR have very different perspectives, almost all have been motivated by the charge of "correlationism" as formulated by the French philosopher Quentin Meillassoux to describe

almost all philosophies in the Western tradition. “By ‘correlation,’” Meillassoux tells us,

we mean the idea according to which we only ever have access to the correlation between thinking and being, and never to either term considered apart from the other. . . . Correlationism consists in disqualifying the claim that it is possible to consider the realms of subjectivity and objectivity independently of one another. Not only does it become necessary to insist that we never grasp an object “in itself,” in isolation from its relation to the subject, but it also becomes necessary to maintain that we can never grasp a subject that would not always-already be related to an object. (2008, 5)

Husserl, for instance, would be an archetypal correlationist thinker since he begins with the relation between a perceiving subject and an object. Friedrich Nietzsche would be an exemplar of a correlationist philosopher when he says, “Against that positivism which stops before phenomena, saying ‘there are only *facts*,’ I should say: no, it is precisely facts that do not exist, only *interpretations*” (1968, 458), by which he means that there is no unmediated, unclouded access to the “facts” of the world, thus privileging an interpreting subject. But, Meillassoux argues, the world existed prior to human activity and will exist after human extinction. The usual terms of philosophy have no way of grasping this exterior world and instead reduce everything to human thought—which, Meillassoux suggests, is intrinsically idealist. Meillassoux finds this to be a deep problem, one that denies the existence of the world outside of our limited perspective.

The critique of correlationism—and the claim that language, consciousness, mind, and so on are all idealist—has been taken up by SR to advocate for a return to “reality itself” and “the nature of reality” independent “of thought and of humanity more generally” (Bryant, Srnicek, and Harman 2011, 3). Other advocates for new kinds of realism, like Maurizio Ferraris (2014a), also argue that theories which have long characterized continental philosophy—in particular, philosophy that descends from the claims of Nietzsche—too readily deny the existence of a singular, universal reality and truth. The turn to reality, for Ferraris, should be what philosophy and theory work to perform. He sees the turn to reality and realism as political, as something that can work to undermine current populisms that employ the lies of media propaganda to achieve power (2015, 21). Other SR writers see this turn to a world beyond the human as one that will bring about a more equitable reality that refuses to deny the agencies of nonhuman actors, following some of the arguments of the anthropologist and theorist Bruno

Latour (see Harman 2009). Even others see the rejection of correlationism as necessary for a kind of human liberation (Bogost 2012). We're reducing the possibilities of the world in linking it to human knowledge and experience, this line of thinking suggests. Moving beyond human experience would, in realist philosophy, expand the possibilities for the world and the materiality of the things within it.

We covered some of this in Chapter 1. The turn to materiality corresponds with this turn to realism. There's a widespread belief that a focus on images, representations, and so on means that we're not looking at "reality." While our claim was that representations are material, in that they do material things and have material effects, participating in processes that produce "reality," this answer is not the one given by New and Speculative Realisms. So, we should work to understand the differences between these realist perspectives and our materialist one, and what we might want to take from these emerging forms of realism. But this also means that we have to understand the problems with New and Speculative Realisms.

Most notably, these authors do not—and cannot—do what they advocate. While their philosophies are deeply committed toward removing the "privilege" given to human beings and human knowledge, in practice they cannot decenter the human so radically—if merely because they're human beings writing books to be read for other humans, with arguments expressed in language, reflecting the potentials and limitations of language. The very idea of "subjects" and "objects" corresponds to the structure of language, for instance, and would suggest that a world seen through these distinctions would be an expression of how particular human beings perceive the world through language. New and Speculative Realisms rely almost entirely on describing a reality perceivable to human beings (cf. Golumbia 2016, 23–24). Or, as essayist Brian Dillon has claimed, these theories—while supposedly about objects and things—have a tendency to obliterate the particularity of that which they pretend to theorize. The objects these theories tend to discuss exist entirely as lists without elaboration. "A philosophy of the object without objects, a materiality without materials—what good are these to anyone except the intellectually immature and overreaching" (2017, 80), Dillon states. SR seems limited to depicting a "real" world that is everywhere and nowhere, legitimated only through its claims of (speculative) access to the real, rather than any particular commentary on actual objects.

Realist philosophies also gloss over wide swaths of philosophy and theory, and often make strawpersons out of those they write against. Meillassoux's arguments about correlationism depend on a limited reading of the history of Western philosophy, one that cannot account for the vast majority of

analytic philosophy (including the materialist philosophy of mind discussed in Chapter 4, which works to make sure thought and mind are not “idealist”). Even with the most extreme version of the “anti-realist” arguments addressed by New and Speculative Realisms—“anti-realist” theorists seemingly deny the existence of an external reality beyond human experience, and deny an objective reality or “truth” beyond mediation—it’s clear that realists either distort or misrepresent the claims of those they implicitly position themselves against. Jean Baudrillard is perhaps the archetypal writer who denies the existence of “reality” and “truth” in recent decades, arguing that the contemporary world is characterized by “simulacra,” or copies without originals that act to determine reality in accordance with the copy. The world is remade to correspond to a fictional or simulated model, the “map” precedes the “territory,” and the boundary between “real” and “representation” is eroded so a distinction between the two cannot be made. In the notorious book *The Gulf War Did Not Take Place* (1995), Baudrillard seemingly denies the existence of the Gulf War of the early 1990s, but Baudrillard’s title is ironic. Arguing that Baudrillard is denying reality is to miss his point. Baudrillard is interested in how war is mediated in the West. The mediated image precedes and determines the “reality” of war in a way that a distinction between “real” and “representation” cannot be made. “Reality” is the representation for Baudrillard. The evidence we have of the Gulf War is that of televised images and games—a fact that has continued to transform war today, when weapons like drones kill through interfaces that blur “actual” war with video game simulations of war, and war is legitimated through mainstream games and entertainment (cf. Lenoir and Caldwell 2018). Or, mediated images are not idealistic but are material and real, in that they organize material reality, affects, and behaviors, intersecting and assembling human and nonhuman. Saying that critiques of media imagery are not “realist” because of their focus on images and fiction, and how images and fiction have guided decisions, actions, and beliefs, is to misread and misunderstand the very point of this critique of media—and is to deny how thought and cognition are themselves material.

Several of the writers associated with SR have moved toward what they term “Object-Oriented Ontology” (OOO) in recent years, attempting to correct some of these issues by supplementing realism with the Heideggerian claims about the withdrawal of objects. Graham Harman, the theorist most clearly associated with developing both SR and OOO, has claimed that OOO is a realist theory, but not a materialist one. Because of the withdrawal of objects from each other there’s no direct contact between objects, and no intrinsic relationality between objects (2018, 12). OOO is a “theory of everything” for Harman, one guided by rejecting four assumptions. First,

OOO denies that everything real must be basic and simple, reducible to basic elements or units. Second, it rejects the idea that something real can be described in direct, literalist language. Third, it rejects the idea that for something to be real it must exist—or, OOO argues that something fictional is still real. Fourth, it rejects the idea that everything real must be physical—thus, it refuses the materialism we’ve been outlining in this book.

I agree with the rejection of the first two of these assumptions. Both of these are a critique of people like Daniel Dennett, discussed in Chapter 4, along with the scientific worldview he espouses. Science regularly breaks down material objects into constituent parts, from DNA to chemical elements. This idea is called “reductionism” as it reduces everything to parts, arguing that reality can be understood as emerging from the physical aspects of these small, basic elements, but reductionism is not universally accepted by all scientists. Complexity science opposes reductionism on scientific terms, arguing that phenomena like weather patterns cannot be understood through small, basic parts (see Mitchell 2009). A common argument from complexity science is that “more is different.” The entire system must be accounted for to identify emergent phenomena that would not occur without the “more” of a larger scale. Or, one wouldn’t be able to explain tornadoes or hurricanes if one only reduced the weather to its basic elements. OOO, like complexity science, argues that real things cannot be broken into basic parts, though it doesn’t do so by turning to interactions and relations. Regardless, OOO refuses to separate objects into their constituent elements.

The idea that reality can be discussed in literal terms is linked with efforts to reduce reality into parts. If we can reduce something to its basic elements, this line of thinking goes, then we can avoid subjective language for, say, feelings, emotions, and experience. We’d be able to describe pleasurable experiences through the measurement of dopamine in our brains or the taste of food and wine through their chemical composition and the way chemicals interact with one’s taste buds. This is a conclusion that Dennett comes to and is one of the ways he denies the significance of human consciousness. A machine can analyze a glass of wine by understanding its chemical composition, for instance. Dennett sees this process as analogous to the sensation of drinking a glass of wine at the level of the brain. The common terms we use, which may refer to a particular berry flavor, or something else subjective, Dennett sees as approximations for physical processes in the brain and body that can be directly described. Dennett would say, then, the mechanical analysis of chemicals is, in actuality, of no significant difference than what’s happening in our body when we taste something (see Harman 2018, 37).

I generally agree with these objections, though I don’t agree with why Harman rejects them. The reason that OOO rejects these two arguments

is because of Heideggerian arguments about withdrawal. In breaking down an object into its parts and in focusing on literal, scientific language to describe these parts, OOO argues that one is conflating the ready-to-hand and the present-at-hand. One ignores the essence of the object and, instead, focuses only on what is sensible (be it to humans or to technologies for measurement). OOO argues that these kinds of reductionism and literal description inevitably miss the object, reducing the object to its parts or its sensory properties, when, in actuality, the object is withdrawn.

Unlike Harman, I'd instead suggest that, following complexity science, more is different at a material level and, when it comes to literalist description, particular effects (like "taste") can only be understood in relation with the material, chemical composition of an object and of the particular body consuming it. Or, something like taste is intra-active and thus cannot be reduced to the basic components of one and not the other. So, these objections can be useful for questions of materialism and materiality, but not the answers Harman supplies as to why we might make these rejections.

Harman's other two claims are more questionable—and our discussion of these claims will continue to demonstrate two different ways of rejecting the idea that objects can be reduced to basic elements.

Harman's third denial suggests that something fictional may not be physical but is nonetheless real. This denial is easy to dismiss. Fictional stories always exist in a physical medium and are an expression of the physical capacities of a medium. They are imagined in the mind according to the physical capacities of imagination and thought. Thus, fiction is material because of the materiality of a medium, which would mean that different incarnations of a story are often radically different because of the contextual, material particularities of how a story is told. Harman, however, wants to suggest that fictional characters remain consistent objects over time. So, the "Sherlock Holmes" of Arthur Conan Doyle is, effectively, the same "Sherlock Holmes" depicted by Benedict Cumberbatch in the television show *Sherlock*. I think it's fairly safe to reject this idea. Even though these characters share the same name, along with a number of other aspects in their depiction, there are countless differences as well, many of which have to do with how a medium inscribes particular details of, say, language, set design, costuming, actors' bodies, physical description, and so on. There is not one constant object called "Sherlock Holmes," but multiple objects determined by the capacities of a medium to inscribe.

Harman's final denial is more difficult to do away with, however. Harman denies that everything real must be physical—which is a guiding argument for this entire book. Harman (2016) justifies this claim through the example of the Dutch East India Company, known as the *Vereenigde Oostindische*

Compagnie in the Netherlands, or the VOC, which was founded in 1602 and disbanded in 1799. The VOC was the world's first publicly traded company and—as an agent of Dutch imperialism—was given powers such as the ability to declare war, to mint its own currency, and to establish colonies. Harman argues that the VOC should be taken as an object, in and of itself, an object that cannot be reduced to its parts, an object distinct from the Dutch state. It's also, he claims, an object that should be thought to be static over time rather than something constantly changing in spite of the consistency of its name. Thus, the VOC is not “material” because it has to exist in excess of its material elements. It is singular, rather than a series of different material arrangements—all of which are named the VOC but all of which are, in fact, different because of the particularity of their material parts. Again, we see how Heidegger's claims about the Thing are central to some of the claims of OOO. The object exists in excess of its material formation. It has to stand independently, obscured by its materiality. Its independence means that it exists beyond its material parts, its sensory expression, its particular form, and so on—it has to have a consistent “essence” that exceeds its physicality.

Harman's arguments resemble a classical philosophical paradox known as “the ship of Theseus” (see Plutarch 1960, 29). Let's say there exists a ship that sailed in battle by the mythical Greek hero Theseus, kept in a harbor for posterity. As the ship gets older, its wooden planks start to rot and are gradually replaced. After a century or so all of its parts are replaced. Is the ship now in the harbor the same ship that Theseus once sailed?

Harman follows those who claim that the “new” ship was the same ship, such as Aristotle, who proposed a solution via his system of “fourfold causality,” which Harman and Heidegger have both drawn on in their writings (see Harman 2010). For Aristotle, an object is composed out of four causes, a “formal cause,” or its design, a “material cause,” or its physical materiality, an “efficient cause,” or the agency of the fabricator, and a “final cause,” which is the object's intended use. Even though the ships are different in their material cause and efficient cause—the material planks are different, the ships were constructed by different people—the formal cause and final cause are the same—the “old” and “new” ships have the same form and have the same “use” as an object. Aristotle argued that the restored ship was the same because of the final cause, which is, for him, what gives a particular identity to an object—the privileging of which we can also see when Heidegger emphasizes the use of “the Thing” as pertaining to its essence, even though Heidegger and OOO move beyond this Aristotelian model. For them, the consistency of a withdrawn essence beyond use is what makes the object the same over time.

Other ancient Greek philosophers, like Heraclitus, argued instead that the new ship was fundamentally different, though that's in part because of the

inherent constant of material, physical change—for Heraclitus, everything is constantly differing over time. The materialist theory in this book follows Heraclitus more than Aristotle, though this emphasis on change and flux rejects most claims to coherent or consistent identity over time. Materialist theory would argue that the “you” of this moment is different than the “you” of your childhood, different than the “you” of your adolescence, different than the “you” of a few weeks, days, even minutes ago. Each of these moments involves a range of material facts that are distinct and different. OOO would argue that you are always the same object, regardless of the changes that may have taken place.

The point here is not to say that OOO is inherently wrong and materialism is inherently correct. The point is to note that OOO’s theory of objects, derived from a long-standing tradition of philosophy that denies the equation of an object with its physical materiality, seems like it would resonate with what we’ve been discussing in this book, though it comes to very different conclusions, which have different political implications. Harman accuses theories (like materialism) that do not allow for an “excess” beyond physical materiality of “overmining” what they study, which means that an object is “reduced” to what it does or how it relates and interacts with others. This is, for him, a sin that completely denies the existence of objects (2018, 49). Regardless, with OOO we get a philosophy of objects that argues “objects” exist only as some immaterial essence, an essence that is nowhere in particular and does nothing, but is beyond and outside of the physical interactions and relations that materially exist. There is an “objectness” beyond the immanence of the object’s material, physical parts.

Hopefully, you can already see some of the ways we might object to Harman. If we go back to our chapter on inscription, for instance, the original, physical thing matters as a marker of something inscribed. The particular parts matter because of their physical link with something that has actually happened in the past, something “documented” in a physical medium. If we think back to our chapter on space and time, when archaeology goes back to look at these “documents” it does so by subjecting an actual, physical object to, say, a series of tests that—depending on the intent and use of particular archaeological techniques—can potentially reveal knowledge about history. The materials used in the original would produce vastly different knowledge than the materials used in the reconstruction, in part because there’d be different inscriptions accumulating in the wood, which would be a result of the particular routes the ship itself sailed. And even if we think of the inscriptions of paperwork, the Dutch East India Company only existed as an object because of the documentation, contracts, and stock that existed to give it transnational authority, documents and contracts that had particular

biases because of the physicality of the media they employed, legitimated because of how different national bodies “materialized.” The only reason that the VOC was given the powers of governmental authority was because of its authorization as an agent of imperialist trade, which created unequal relations that manifested materially as colonial domination and exploitation.

These details matter. They shape the particular form an object takes as it “materializes.” Changes in physical materiality reinvent and transform the existence of a particular object. A materialist perspective allows us to acknowledge the varied actors and agencies that work together to create the reality we live. The theory of objects given by OOO does not. All it allows us to say is that objects exist. But we can’t say anything about an object beyond this statement of its existence. OOO should probably be thought of as the pinnacle of “idealism,” not realism. In it, objects end up being immaterial “things,” unknowable idealist forms without matter, unchanging and stable—even though OOO denies the existence of a mind to have these ideas.

There are points that we should take from OOO and SR—we should embrace its attention to a world beyond the human and its rejection of particular kinds of reduction that turn objects into nothing other than their constituent elements. But, at the same time, we should recognize the fundamental incompatibility of OOO with materialist theories of media, though the encounter of OOO and materialist theory also reveals how we should deny certain things—like a coherent sense of identity over time—in favor of contingent, multiple, and relational processes. While there have been a number of critiques of OOO and SR that demonstrate how it rarely lives up to its own demands (i.e., Wolfendale 2014), it’s on this point that we’ll turn to Jane Bennett’s vital materialism. While Bennett shares a number of concerns of OOO, a point noted by Harman (2018, 240–43), she emphasizes physical materiality, relation, and the agency of nonhuman objects, providing a theory of objects and relations more in line with the materiality discussed in this book. At the same time, Bennett’s ontology is totalizing, and if OOO tends to overstate the absolute alterity of objects by deferring to an unknowable essence beyond physical materiality, vital materialism overstates the intertwining of the world as a whole, evacuating the possibilities for political encounters and difference.

Vital objects and affective energies

Jane Bennett’s vital materialism attempts to acknowledge the vast range of agencies beyond the human and places all things on equal ontological ground—something Harman has noted that it shares with OOO (2018,

240–43). But vital materialism differs from OOO because of its emphasis on physical materiality, relation, and—significantly—the vital “energies” that exist within objects that permit them to act. Vitalism typically defers to a kind of “life force” that animates something from within, perhaps best represented by Henri Bergson’s concept of *élan vital*, or “vital impetus,” which is an animating, biological energy that exists within organisms, causing them to move, develop, and endure in time without any concrete ending “goal” (1911, 51). Bennett sees theories of vitality, such as the one given by Bergson, as too easily separating matter from the animating energy that exists “within” an organism. Instead, she wants to argue that this animating energy is inherent to matter, and all matter has a capacity to act and *affect*. So, there are two things that we should note about vital materialism. First, it stresses the physical materiality of objects. But, second, it adds to this by theorizing agency as an *affective energetics* linked with the relational capacity to affect and be affected by others.

Bennett argues—drawing on the long-standing difference between objects and things—that we need to stress *thing-power*, or “the curious ability of inanimate things to animate, to act, to produce effects dramatic and subtle” (2010, 6), the ability of there to be an agentic excess that—while it may not exceed materiality—is nonetheless beyond the typical ways humans have of understanding objects. This thing-power can be seen most clearly with waste. Waste seems like it may be the most “inanimate” of inanimate objects. From empty aluminum cans to paper, to plastic, to old VCRs and mobile phones that are broken and no longer function, these are all things that don’t seem to “do” much of anything. Waste has no clear “use,” and it often lacks a “form”—Heidegger’s discussion of things wouldn’t appear to apply to waste because we never “use” waste. Waste seems to be “stuff” that we attempt to dispose of and forget. But, as Bennett notes, many of our current ecological crises are produced by waste as it decays, rots, and falls apart, and as the chemicals and minerals in waste leech out and contaminate the water, food, and soil around us. In thinking of these things as inanimate forms of waste, we overlook the vast range of ways that waste is actively reshaping reality.

The materiality of waste is *the same* materiality of human and animal life. In ignoring the physical composition of waste, we’re neglecting the physicality that composes human bodies (12–13). The human body is made up of minerals, acids, and compounds that come not just from within, but from what we eat and consume. Mercury, for instance, is a toxic metal that enters the air not only from volcanoes but also from the burning of coal for power, the refining of oil, and the production of chlorine. Mercury then is absorbed from the air into the water, where—as it moves through the food chain—it accumulates in the bodies of fish like tuna and halibut, then eaten

by humans, accumulating in our own bodies as a toxic substance that can, in significant amounts, damage the nervous system. Materially, our bodies are linked with other living things and objects as they agentially move throughout the planet. Our biology is remade in accordance with the material waves—like radiation—we contact. With mobile phones and Wi-Fi, these effects aren't clearly understood yet. For Bennett, this shared materiality of the human body and the things and objects in the world is an ethical one, because human life and the life of the world are completely intertwined.

So, in vital materialism there cannot be a divide between subject and object because, as Bennett argues, everything exists as “one matter-energy, the maker of things seen and unseen” (122). The singular understanding of “matter” Bennett gives us means we are all literally comprised of the same “stuff.” But this still neglects what she means by “vitality” and “agency,” which should be thought of in relation to theories of *affect*.

“Affect,” as used in a wide range of contemporary theory, descends from some of the arguments of philosopher Baruch Spinoza, along with William James's claim that consciousness and experience happen *after* a physical, bodily change, and that “mind” and sensation are secondary to the physicality of the body and brain. Perhaps the most significant recent theorization of affect is Brian Massumi's essay “The Autonomy of Affect” (2002), which makes a hard distinction between affect and emotion following Spinoza and James—for Massumi, an emotion is a qualified, captured description of a bodily experience that happens after the fact, while an affect is something material, bodily, and relational. Similar claims can be found in many attempts to theorize affect. For Teresa Brennan, affects are “material, physiological things” (2006, 6) transmitted between different bodies, demonstrating how “we are not self-contained in terms of our energies” (6). For the anthropologist Kathleen Stewart, affect is “transpersonal or prepersonal—not about one person's feelings becoming another's but about bodies literally affecting one another and generating intensities: human bodies, discursive bodies, bodies of thought, bodies of water” (2007, 128). What characterizes all of these authors is that affect is something physical and physiological.

Affect, then, comes to describe an “energy” that moves between bodies, through them. Sometimes, it is clearly felt, if not easily put into words. Sometimes, it exists prior to consciousness and, while it has a material effect, cannot be located within an individual's consciousness clearly. It's this affectivity that leads Lisa Blackman to the claim cited in Chapter 4—that instead of bodies we should speak of body-brain-world entanglements. Affect is the material means that these entanglements happen, an energetic substance that exceeds and moves between individuals, linking them to each other and to the world. Affect is also the means that permits Bennett to claim

that her vitalism is a materialism—affect comes to refer to the energetic potential within materiality to act and affect others.

I agree with the general argument presented by affect theory—we should understand relationality and interaction as material, and that these relational, material interactions are about movement and change. Affect directs us to the physical energies that bridge different bodies, and to the active capacities of bodies to move. But affect too easily drifts into becoming a metaphysical substance beyond materiality, and, I worry, it may become something akin to **aether** (which can also be spelled ether) in the near future (see Milutis 2006). Aether is the name of a theoretical “element” that, from ancient and medieval science through the nineteenth century, was something thought to materially fill space. It was used to account for gravity and the movement of light. Few, if any, scientists believe in the existence of aether today. Nonetheless, aether was thought to be a material substance that existed, even though we couldn’t perceive or experience it. The legacy of aether should cause us to pause in any description of a material “substance” that causes particular effects even though it can’t be properly identified or defined in a consistent way.

In drifting toward the metaphysical, there arise a few issues we can see in affect theory: affect tends to produce an odd kind of anthropomorphism, in which everything “feels” and becomes “sentient” (Angerer 2017, 21). In spite of the fact that a number of affect theorists draw attention to alterity and difference, the emphasis on intersubjective flows has led some theorists to either deny the possibility of subjectivity (see Blackman 2012; Terada 2001) or argue for a totalized, singular world in which absolute interconnection means that one can speak neither of causes and effects nor interventions to provoke change, leading to a pessimistic worldview in which the agency of an individual or group simply cannot do anything (cf. Bollmer 2016b). And, finally, the materialist arguments advanced by many affect theorists suggest that affect must be a “thing” found in the physiology of the body that is both material and exists beyond materiality. This leads affect theorists to discuss biology and neurology in ways that are often shockingly reductive and partial (see Blackman 2012, 134; Bollmer 2014; Papoulias and Callard 2010; Leys 2017), plundering from psychology and neuroscience without acknowledging the political implications of the model of the human body and mind these theories demand. Let me briefly address these three problems in turn.

Anthropomorphism and animism

The particular form of anthropomorphism that characterizes vital materialist thought is **animistic**. “Affect” becomes a kind of internalized, overflowing energy, a new “spirit” that animates the bodies of living and nonliving things

alike. Animism, most broadly defined, means little more than a belief in spirits. It characterizes certain variants of Western theology, but recent uses of animism in theory are more often derived from Pagan, indigenous, or Eastern belief systems beyond Western modernity (see Harvey 2013). The similarities that these theological animisms have with theoretical claims of vital entanglement turn “new animism” into an onto-ethical imperative. Timothy Morton, a theorist associated with OOO, suggests that he aims to reimagine “what counts as people,” and that “Ancient animisms treat beings as people. . . . Perhaps I’m aiming for an upgraded version of animism” (2010, 8). Donna Haraway, the famed feminist theorist of science, suggests, citing a conversation with anthropologist Eduardo Viveiros de Castro, “Animism is the only *sensible* version of materialism,” the only ontology that permits for the sense-ability of agencies and actors beyond humanity (2016, 88–89). While Bennett, in particular, resolutely affirms how these “spirits” must exist materially, refusing to turn toward an immaterial metaphysical “thing” that animates the agencies of bodies and objects separate from materiality, she nonetheless turns to the theological concept of animism because of its seeming location “outside” of Western thought (2010, xviii, 18).

This turn toward animism is a problem in contemporary theory. The invocation of animism is made with explicit reference to premodern or Eastern modes of thinking, orientalistically fetishizing particular varieties of thought that are “other” from the West. As I’ve written in collaboration with the art historian Katherine Guinness,

The animistic is positioned as closer to nature, as removed from the ethical problems of Western individualism, and is discussed almost entirely through reference to indigeneity or Eastern spirituality. In short, we ask, does embracing the agency of objects and images rely on an ontotheological assumption that requires animistic spirituality? And, if so, is it possible to do this without perpetuating an implicitly orientalist relationship towards Eastern or indigenous spiritualistic “tradition”? (2018, 81)

Or, there’s a difference between theories that claim something is animated by particular energies and forces, and others that end up deferring to a kind of animated “soul” that exists within things. This likewise drifts into beliefs in *panpsychism*, which is a belief that attributes a mind to all matter (cf. Shaviri 2014), and also relates to how contemporary claims about affect have a strong similarity with nineteenth-century spiritualism, and particularly spiritualism’s emphasis on a “flowing force” that bridges different entities (Blackman 2012, 68). Regardless, the tendency to refer to animism is a way

in which metaphysical “substances” and agencies creep back into materialist theories of objects and affects.

Alterity and totality

According to Brian Massumi, affect directs us to how the “concepts of nature and culture need serious reworking, in a way that expresses the irreducible *alterity* of the nonhuman in and through its active *connection* to the human and vice versa” (2002, 39). This is a particularly difficult claim to enact in theory, though it’s one that I agree with. But claims about affect too often forget the aspect of alterity that Massumi highlights, instead focusing on the intertwining and interrelations of all things (see Bollmer 2016b). We can see this at work in one of the few concrete examples that Bennett gives about the political implications of her vital materialism, a “politics” that emerges when one highlights the agentic interconnection of everything. Of a 2003 blackout in the Northeastern United States and Canada, Bennett claims, “The electrical grid, by blacking out, lit up quite a lot: the shabby condition of the public-utilities infrastructure, the law-abidingness of New York City residents living in the dark, the disproportionate and accelerating consumption of energy by North Americans, and the element of unpredictability marking assemblages composed of intersecting and resonating elements” (2010, 36). The blackout affected around ten million people in Ontario and forty-five million in eight American states, including New York, New Jersey, Pennsylvania, and Massachusetts, leaving many without power for several days or even over a week. It was primarily caused by a software bug in the control room of Ohio company FirstEnergy, which failed to properly distribute energy across its many power lines, leading to an overload. The software bug (which was part of General Electric’s XA/21 energy management system) delayed an alarm from being triggered by over an hour. Those working for FirstEnergy were thus unaware of what was happening in the power grid they maintained, and—by the time they became aware—their computers were failing, their power lines overloading all across North America.

For Bennett, the blackout reveals that a range of events happen at the intersection of human and nonhuman agencies. I think we can agree. The blackout was caused by the infrastructure of the power grid, the software of FirstEnergy’s computers, and the (in)ability of FirstEnergy’s workers to see (and do) certain things about the problem. The everyday effects of the blackout—the lives of the many individuals living without power, their appliances and lights nonfunctional—only happened because of the vast range of interconnections between humans, technologies, and objects elsewhere. But Bennett makes an odd jump from this argument:

Must a distributive, composite notion of agency thereby abandon the attempt to hold individuals responsible for their actions or hold officials accountable to the public? The directors of the FirstEnergy corporation were all too eager to reach this conclusion in the task force report: no one really is to blame. Though it is unlikely that the energy traders shared my vital materialism, I, too, find it hard to assign the strongest or most punitive version of moral responsibility to them. Autonomy and strong responsibility seem to me to be empirically false, and thus their invocation seems tinged with injustice. In emphasizing the ensemble nature of action and the interconnections between persons and things, a theory of vibrant matter presents individuals as simply incapable of bearing *full* responsibility for their effects. (2010, 37)

While Bennett hedges her claim (she merely denies that individuals must bear *full* responsibility for their actions) the blackout *did* have a particular cause—a software bug—though its effects far exceeded the particular GE XA/21 that caused the blackout because of this bug. This problem has a clear solution. FirstEnergy should not rely so heavily on automated technological systems; they should be sure that their software is checked and tested more rigorously, and their power grid should be strengthened to prevent overloading even without these particular problems. Energy companies should be made to take steps to ensure this happens, enforced by regulatory governmental agencies. But this is not the “solution” Bennett gives. While Bennett does not say that this means there is literally nothing to do, she does end up arguing that “the ethical responsibility of an individual human now resides in one’s response to the assemblages in which one finds oneself participating: Do I attempt to extricate myself from assemblages whose trajectory is likely to do harm? Do I enter into the proximity of assemblages whose conglomerate effectivity tends toward the enactment of nobler ends?” (37–38). Following this directive would do little, if anything, to correct for the particular causes of the blackout. Switching to a different energy provider would probably do nothing—many of those affected by the blackout were not FirstEnergy customers—and the particular problems *would* be corrected by additional regulatory oversight and testing—things that, again, most customers wouldn’t be able to directly influence on their own. While one could remove themselves from the energy grid, living without power in a cabin on a lake, the vast majority of individuals do not have the privilege or ability to extricate themselves from the bonds of their daily lives that Bennett seems to unintentionally advocate for in her discussion of this case. Or, Bennett makes “politics” about little more than individual choice and decision (see Lemke 2018),

even though “interconnection” seems to make individual action irrelevant (Bollmer 2016b).

So, there are problems with this ethical claim, but we should also learn a few things from it. Let’s begin by elaborating in more depth the problems by looking at other examples. On the one hand, the kind of interconnection that Bennett claims to exist is totalizing, founded on the claim that we exist as part of “one matter-energy” (2010, 122). Even were we to acknowledge that, within this one matter-energy, we could differentiate clearly between one network or assemblage rather than another, the ability that one could merely extricate themselves from a particular assemblage is questionable—again, people who were not FirstEnergy consumers were affected by the blackout. Many of the technological and economic networks you participate in may be things completely unknown to you. The vast majority of savings and retirement plans in Western countries, for instance, are linked with the stock market, in ways that permit one a very low choice in terms what companies are being invested rather than another. To merely withdraw one’s participation in these financial networks—while possible—is extraordinarily difficult for the vast majority of people. To use another example, because of economic integration, most entertainment companies have some investment in the military and war, and often willingly collaborate with the military in numerous ways, which theorist James Der Darian (2009) terms the “military-industrial-entertainment-media network.” If one wanted to be sure to avoid supporting war and the military, one probably would also have to cease to consuming media and accessing the internet, as—merely by paying Spectrum or Comcast to access the internet—you’re probably giving money to a corporation that profits off war.

These examples are economic, and the solution is rarely, if ever, to remove oneself from these networks, but—collaboratively, collectively—to put pressure on governments and institutions to change policies or laws. A number of Australian universities have disinvested from energy companies that burn fossil fuels because of pressure from students and employees, for instance. This speaks not only to a kind of intertwining but also to how there are multiple, differential sets of relations that have limits, and not that there’s “one matter-energy” of total connection. But the choice here is not individual. It has to be made through collective negotiation of relations, through organizing, through popular politics that remake relations rather than withdraw from them. The idea of individualized “exit,” while popular in a range of political theories today, only works if one has the privilege or ability to simply break free of the bonds that sustain daily life, a privilege that invests in some bodies more than others (see Sharma 2017).

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Problem
"exit" as
consumption*

Bennett's claims about energetic intertwining can be helpful, as long as we avoid a sense of a "one" in which all are equally part, and avoid making politics about individual choice. Relations are not equally distributed, and while we may all exist within one world, that world is divided up and differentiated from within. We have to pay as much attention to difference and alterity—and how differences materialize and are maintained—to the relations and connections that exist between people and things. Networks stop, energies dissipate. Who one is "with" is as important as who one is "against."

Affect and the materiality of the brain

One of the biggest problems with affect theory, however, comes from how its materiality is defined. If affect is material, and it exists prior to thought and consciousness, then it should exist in the very physicality of the body. This returns us to the concerns of Chapter 4. Affect has to be physiological—or at least seems as if it *should be* physiological. Lisa Blackman has summarized this problem with the following: because affect disavows the spiritual, psychic, or metaphysical, it

plunders from the "hard" edges of psychological and biological theorizing in order to offer up suggestions for the possible mechanisms that will explain the transmission of affect. . . . These attempts . . . retreat to the *singular* neurophysiological body in order to explain the transmission of affect *between* people. Thus, an understanding of the psychological complexity that would make the transmission of affect intelligible is reduced to the brain and the central nervous system. (2012, 77–78)

Affect theorists have a tendency to draw on various neuropsychological or psychological studies, many of which have deep flaws or are selectively chosen because of similarities with "material," biological explanations and the claims of Spinoza and James (see Leys 2017; Papoulias and Callard 2010). Affect theory too often "relies on invoking the nervous system, endocrine system, or a particular neuropsychological concept, such as the mirror neuron, in order to animate the body's lively processuality" (Blackman 2012, 134)—a problem further compounded by the fact that, say, mirror neurons—a neurological mechanism found in macaque monkeys that provides a physiological explanation for the mirroring of facial expressions, which many psychologists believe is central for the neurobiology of empathy—have not been proven to exist in humans. In spite of the stated goals to identify the materiality of relation between bodies, undermining the individuality of

subjectivity, these turns toward the brain end up reaffirming the singularity of the individual as defined by the materiality of the brain.

Additionally, the neurobiology of affect and emotion is used to define particular brains and bodies as disordered, as unable to “feel” properly because they, supposedly, lack the neurological mechanism that allows a brain to experience felt relation. Best seen in the diagnosis of autism, psychopathy, and borderline personality disorder, all of which are defined in contemporary neuropsychology by a malfunction of the brain’s “empathy circuit,” specific bodies are defined as lacking a particular physiological capacity by the same body of research that affect theory uses to define affect as a biological—even ontological—capacity of the human body (see Bollmer 2014). The result is a weird, circular set of contradictions. Neuroscience and neuropsychology identify a particular set of biological mechanisms to describe the physiological processes of relation, which are taken up by affect theorists to define the material existence of affect as an ontological—and even political—force that means “relation” is located within the body. However, neuroscience and neuropsychology also use these same biological mechanisms to identify specific bodies to be pathologized or corrected, as “abnormal” because of their lack of particular brain functions. Some neuropsychologists even argue that these bodies may be best thought of as “evil” because they lack the physiological ability to experience “empathy” (see Baron-Cohen 2011). But affect theory, because it has taken these physiological mechanisms to explain the materiality of human relation, cannot acknowledge the historical construction of particular disorders; it relies on accepting the same physiological explanation for affect and relation that is used to identify psychopathy, autism, and borderline personality disorder as particular neurological problems.

Relations and oppositions

So, we have two perspectives on objects that seem completely incompatible. One, associated with SR and OOO, relies on, as Marie-Luise Angerer has put it, “an impenetrable wall between subject and object” (2017, 21). The other, vital materialism, stresses the “life” of both animate and inanimate matter, their relations, agencies, and intertwining, brought together by a physical “affect” that moves beyond and between subject and object. If one emphasizes isolation and separation, the other holistic interconnection. We should embrace these key arguments of both of these bodies of thought. We should say that objects are independent from humans, emphasizing their alterity and their Otherness. But these objects do not exceed their materiality;

they do not possess some “essence” that exists outside of their material relations. Instead, we are in relation with these objects, acting with them, and the boundaries between self and other are regularly transgressed or remade. This does not lead to a singular “oneness” or holism, and it doesn’t need to defer to “affect” as something that uneasily moves between the physical and metaphysical. It leads to a multiplicity of oppositional assemblages that exist because the lines between them are maintained.

The perspective I’m offering here bears a great deal of similarity to Katherine Behar’s reimagining of OOO as “OOF” (2016), and it returns us to Sara Ahmed’s concerns with which we began. Behar wants to embrace OOO’s emphasis on withdrawn objects but revises OOO in numerous ways that also correct for the tendency of vital materialism to lead outward into infinity. It begins by assuming all beings as objects—it assumes that humans are “objectified” from the outset, and thus argues, like Bennett, that “our common status as matter makes way for continuity between all objects, whether human or nonhuman, organic or inorganic, animate or inanimate” (9). But, in doing this, OOF refuses the claims of OOO to “describe” ontology, and it refuses the seeming futility that emerges from the lack of access subjects have to objects:

OOF emphasizes ontology as a political arrangement, realism as an arena for self-possession and relation, and objecthood as a situational orientation, so as to apprehend and alter objects’ intersectional prospects for self-determination, solidarity, and resistance. The internal resistant quality of objects may deserve our closest attention. (24)

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object
oriented
feminism*

Or, Behar argues that we have to consider an object as independent and withdrawn, but particular objects always engage with other objects in relation. OOF embraces forms of practice—not speculation—to engage with objects in new ways, inventing new ways of materially existing *with* objects that encounter each other, because of (not in spite of) their withdrawn separation. The purpose here is to transform the possibilities of orientation, following Ahmed. How can we be oriented toward new, different, or previously unseen objects? How can we allow new relations and new practices to materialize?

Ahmed also remakes some of these concerns by noting how affect is not just a relation—it’s not just a force that bridges one and another. Rather, Ahmed suggests that affect *surfaces* as emotion not only *between* bodies but also that which orients bodies both together and in opposition:

Emotions shape the very surfaces of bodies, which take shape through the repetition of actions over time, as well as through orientations

towards and away from others. Indeed, attending to emotions might show us how all actions are reactions, in the sense that what we do is shaped by the contact we have with others. (2014, 4)

While affects circulate between bodies, some “stick” in particular ways, producing specific relations between subjects and objects that “materialize” in their repetition. Like vital materialism, Ahmed argues that they are in neither a subject nor in an object, but about how a particular orientation materializes. “Emotions are relational: they involve (re)actions or relations of ‘towardness’ or ‘awayness’ in relation to such objects” (8). Affect allows a particular relation to be sensible and felt, not simply a neutral relation, but a relation toward a particular object, or away from a different object. Affect *orients*, it arranges.

Ahmed’s interest in objects and affects comes from her interest in understanding the particular emotional investments that direct racism, and how particular bodies become “strangers,” defined not as “anyone we do not recognise,” but “as bodies out of place”:

To recognise somebody as a stranger is an affective judgment: a stranger is the one who seems suspicious; the one who lurks. I became interested in how some bodies are “in an instant” judged as suspicious, or as dangerous, as objects to be feared, a judgement that can have lethal consequences. There can be nothing more dangerous to a body than the social agreement that *that* is dangerous. (211)

What Ahmed is talking about is how race—and particularly blackness—can be seen as being “out of place,” and being “out of place” can be used to legitimate killing someone, as seen in the numerous cases in the United States of police violence against African Americans. And here we can see the danger of a perspective that only allows for withdrawn objects, which Ahmed makes by way of a comparison to the Marxist notion of commodity fetishism:

Feelings come to reside in objects, magically, as if they are qualities of or in things, only by cutting those objects off from a wider economy of labour and production. It is then as if fear originates with the arrival of others whose bodies become containers of our fear. Given that containers spill, fear becomes the management of crisis. (227)

For Ahmed, particular feelings do not originate from “inside” an object. They come from how particular bodies come into contact and are oriented toward

this visual reading or coding of racialized bodies is out concern in Coolewin's (1994) "professional vision"

each other. Thinking of certain qualities as being “within” an object denies an entire contextual set of relations that invests or defines particular qualities as linked with specific emotional relations. Instead, these relations are repeated, performed, through which particular relations materialize.

This is also where we can avoid some of the more metaphysical (or neurological) assumptions about affect. We do not need to have a specific biological concept to describe the materiality of relation. Ahmed, unlike Massumi, often privileges emotion rather than affect. She does not suggest that affect is biological, but that affect theory should be linked with a longer history of feminist theory on emotion. By emphasizing orientation, she shows us how emotion is something *performed* and *performative*. We don’t need a substance called affect because we can acknowledge that *acts are material*. The boundaries between self and other are not idealist representations but are linked with the material existence of bodies and how they act toward each other.

Conclusion

Thus, we conclude this chapter by returning to the concerns with which this book began. This chapter examined various theories of objects, in their historical distinction from “things” and in emerging theories of SR and OOO. It examined claims of vital materialism, especially the stress on lively relations. But the oppositional emphases of OOO and vital materialism are incomplete, and thus we worked to bring them together, accepting both OOO’s emphasis on withdrawn objects and the active relationality of vital materialism, uniting these concerns with the arguments of OOF and the claims of Sara Ahmed.

Objects are independent, they are different, and they are separate. But this is not just about the ontological qualities of objects. Rather, objects exist in relation, not just relations of “being with” but relations of opposition, relations that are material and real in their performative enaction. Once again, we return to our arguments about performative materialism, stressing action, agency, and, importantly, opposition and conflict. In doing this, we move from the descriptions of ontology to political agencies and struggles, and how materiality should be part of any theory of media, technology, and politics today.

